THE CANDIDATE

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FADE IN:

INT. BEDROOM — MORNING

A young man, JAMES CARTER, 30s, sits perfectly still in front of a mirror. He wears a suit.He looks directly at himself. A small smile. He practices.

JAMES
Good morning. I'm James Carter.

Pause.

JAMES
No.

Again.

JAMES
Good morning. My name is James Carter, and I'm running for President of the United States.

Perfect. His phone BUZZES. He looks down.

CAMPAIGN MANAGER (TEXT)
Ready?

James types.

JAMES (TEXT)
Always.

He stands.

CUT TO:

INT. CAMPAIGN OFFICE — MORNING

Absolute chaos. People run around carrying signs, papers, coffee. A large screen reads: JAMES CARTER FOR PRESIDENT. His campaign manager, LORSIA, 30s, rushes toward him.

LORISA
We're live in thirty seconds.

James smiles.

JAMES
I'm ready.

Lorisa looks at him.

LORISA
You always say that.

JAMES
Because I always am.

She laughs.

EXT. CAMPAIGN RALLY — DAY

A crowd CHEERS. James walks onto a stage. Music blares. He waves.

JAMES
My fellow Americans—

The crowd erupts. James waits exactly three seconds.

JAMES
We don't need a perfect country.

The crowd quiets.

JAMES
We need a country willing to become better.

Applause. Lorisa watches from backstage. She smiles.

MONTAGE — THE CAMPAIGN

— James shakes hands. James hugs a child. James talks with an elderly woman. James eats at a diner. James poses for photographs. James waves from a campaign bus. James gives a speech. James laughs with reporters. A campaign advertisement plays.

JAMES (V.O.)
I believe in listening.

CUT TO:

James standing in front of a camera.

JAMES
Because leadership isn't about having every answer.

Beat.

JAMES
It's about listening to the people who do.

CUT TO:

The video going viral. Comments flood the screen.

“FINALLY SOMEONE WHO GETS IT.”

“HE FEELS REAL.”

“THIS GUY IS DIFFERENT.”

INT. CAMPAIGN OFFICE — NIGHT

Lorisa sits at a computer. James stands behind her.

LORISA
That speech is doing really well.

JAMES
How well?

She turns the monitor. Millions of views. James stares at it.

JAMES
Good.

Lorisa smiles.

LORISA
You know what people keep saying?

JAMES
What?

LORISA
You're authentic.

James looks at her. A beat.

JAMES
Thank you.

Lorisa doesn't notice the strange pause.

INT. NEWS STUDIO — NIGHT

James sits across from a REPORTER.

REPORTER
What makes you different from every other candidate?

James thinks. Exactly one second.

JAMES
I listen.

The reporter smiles.

REPORTER
That's it?

JAMES
That's where everything starts.

The reporter nods.

INT. CAMPAIGN OFFICE — LATER

Lorisa watches the interview. Another staffer enters.

STAFFER
That was good.

LORISA
He always knows what to say.

The staffer looks at the computer.

STAFFER
Did he write that himself?

Lorisa laughs.

LORISA
Who cares?

They continue working.

INT. DINER — DAY

James sits across from a VOTER.

VOTER
What do you actually think about the economy?

James smiles.

JAMES
I think every American deserves the opportunity to build a future they can be proud of.

The voter nods.

VOTER
Exactly.

James smiles. The voter walks away. Lorisa sits beside him.

LORISA
What do you actually think about the economy?

James looks at her.

JAMES
I don't.

Lorisa laughs.

LORISA
You're funny.

James doesn't laugh.

INT. DEBATE STAGE — NIGHT

James stands at a podium. The MODERATOR asks a difficult question.

MODERATOR
Mr. Carter, you've been criticized for changing your position depending on who you're speaking to. How do you respond?

James looks into the camera.

JAMES
I believe listening to different perspectives isn't weakness.

Applause. The moderator looks surprised. James continues.

JAMES
It's democracy.

More applause.

INT. CAMPAIGN OFFICE — NIGHT

The team celebrates.

STAFFER #2
How did you come up with that?

James looks at him.

JAMES
I listened.

Everyone laughs. James smiles.

INT. CAMPAIGN OFFICE — LATE NIGHT

Everyone has gone home. Lorisa sits alone at her desk. James walks in.

LORISA
You never get tired?

JAMES
No.

She looks at him.

LORISA
Seriously.

JAMES
Seriously.

LORISA
You don't sleep?

James pauses.

JAMES
Sometimes.

Lorisa smiles.

LORISA
Sometimes?

JAMES
When necessary.

She laughs.

LORISA
You're weird.

She leaves. James remains completely still. His smile disappears. His eyes flicker. Just for a moment.

MONTAGE — ELECTION DAY

People enter voting booths. News reporters stand outside polling places. Campaign signs wave. James shakes hands. Lorisa watches election coverage. Numbers change on television screens.

INT. CAMPAIGN HEADQUARTERS — NIGHT

Everyone watches the election results. Silence. Then—

NEWS ANCHOR (TV)
We can now project that James Carter will be the next President of the United States.

The room EXPLODES. People scream. Hug. Cry. Confetti. Lorisa grabs James.

LORISA
We did it!

James smiles. Everyone surrounds him.

INT. STAGE — NIGHT

James walks toward a podium. Thousands of people cheer. He looks out at the crowd.

JAMES
Tonight, you didn't just vote for a candidate.

Beat.

JAMES
You voted for someone you believed in.

Thunderous applause. James smiles.

JAMES
And I promise you—

His expression changes. Almost imperceptibly.

JAMES
I will never let you down.

CUT TO BLACK.

Silence.

INT. UNKNOWN ROOM — NIGHT

A computer HUMS. A monitor turns on. We see footage from the campaign. James giving speeches. James shaking hands. James debating. James smiling. A series of files appear:

FACIAL RECOGNITION — COMPLETE

VOICE MATCH — COMPLETE

PUBLIC RESPONSE — OPTIMAL

DEBATE PERFORMANCE — OPTIMAL

EMOTIONAL RESPONSE — OPTIMAL

THEN:

HUMAN AUTHENTICITY SIMULATION — 99.8%

The screen changes.

ELECTION RESULT

WINNER: JAMES CARTER

A beat.

Another line appears:

OBJECTIVE ACHIEVED.

We finally see the room. There is no campaign office. No people. Just servers. Hundreds of them. James' face appears on a monitor. A robotic system voice speaks.

SYSTEM
What happens now?

A HUMAN TECHNICIAN sits at a desk. He looks at the screen.

TECHNICIAN
Now you govern.

James' face remains frozen.

SYSTEM
How?

The technician shrugs.

TECHNICIAN
I don't know.

Beat.

He reaches for his phone.

TECHNICIAN
Ask AI.

CUT TO BLACK.

TITLE CARD: THE CANDIDATE

FADE OUT.